

88 Athaliah

The daughter of Ahab who seized David's throne and tried to wipe out his line.

Athaliah was a princess of the northern kingdom, a daughter of King Ahab, married into the royal family of Judah. Through her, the worship of Baal that Ahab's house had spread in Israel came south to Jerusalem. She was queen to one king of Judah and mother and counsellor to the next. When her son Ahaziah was killed in Jehu's revolt, she killed the royal heirs and ruled Judah herself for six years. She is the only woman in Scripture to reign over Judah. Yet one baby grandson was hidden from her in the temple. Her story is a dark one, but it shows God keeping his promise to David when that promise hung by a single thread.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Atalyahu</i> , usually explained as "the LORD is exalted"
Family	Daughter of Ahab and granddaughter of Omri, kings of Israel (2 Kings 8:18, 26); wife of Jehoram king of Judah; mother of Ahaziah
Reign	Six years over Judah, c. 841–835 BC (2 Kings 11:3)
Key places	Jerusalem; the temple; the house of Baal in Jerusalem
Key people	Jehoram, Ahaziah, Jehosheba, the young Joash, Jehoiada the priest
Main passages	2 Kings 8:16–27; 11:1–20; 2 Chronicles 22:1–23:21
New Testament	Not named

"And when Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the seed royal."

2 Kings 11:1, KJV

The life of Athaliah

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture does not say when she was born or married, or who her mother was.

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| Before c. 848 BC
<i>Marriage</i> | <p>● A royal alliance</p> <p>King Jehoshaphat of Judah makes an alliance with Ahab by marriage. Athaliah becomes the wife of his son Jehoram, who walks in the ways of Ahab's house. <i>2 Kings 8:16–18; 2 Chronicles 18:1; 21:6</i></p> |
| c. 841 BC
<i>Her son's reign</i> | <p>● Counsellor to evil</p> <p>Her son Ahaziah becomes king of Judah and reigns one year. Chronicles says his mother was his counsellor to do wickedly. <i>2 Kings 8:25–27; 2 Chronicles 22:2–4</i></p> |
| c. 841 BC
<i>Jehu's revolt</i> | <p>● Her son is killed</p> <p>Jehu, anointed to destroy the house of Ahab, kills Ahaziah along with Joram king of Israel. Jehu also kills Ahaziah's relatives. <i>2 Kings 9:27; 10:12–14</i></p> |
| c. 841 BC
<i>Seizes power</i> | <p>● Destroys the royal heirs</p> <p>Athaliah kills the royal family of Judah and takes the throne. But Jehosheba, a king's daughter and Ahaziah's sister, hides the baby Joash. <i>2 Kings 11:1–2; 2 Chronicles 22:10–11</i></p> |
| c. 841–835 BC
<i>Six years</i> | <p>● Rules over Judah</p> <p>She reigns over the land while Joash is hidden in the house of the LORD. Chronicles says her sons broke into the temple and gave its holy things to Baal. <i>2 Kings 11:3; 2 Chronicles 24:7</i></p> |
| c. 835 BC
<i>Seventh year</i> | <p>● "Treason, Treason."</p> <p>Jehoiada crowns Joash in the temple. Athaliah hears the shouting, comes in, and tears her clothes. She is led out and put to death by the horse gate. <i>2 Kings 11:4–16; 2 Chronicles 23:12–15</i></p> |

Key activities

2 Kings 8:26 calls Athaliah "the daughter of Omri," while 2 Kings 8:18 says Jehoram's wife was Ahab's daughter. In Hebrew, "daughter" can mean a female descendant, so she was probably Ahab's daughter and Omri's granddaughter.

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- 1 **Married into David's line.** Her marriage tied Judah's royal house to Ahab's, and her husband Jehoram "walked in the way of the kings of Israel." *2 Kings 8:18; 2 Chronicles 21:6*
 - 2 **Counselled her son.** Chronicles says she was Ahaziah's counsellor "to do wickedly." *2 Chronicles 22:3*
 - 3 **Destroyed the royal family.** When her son died, she killed the heirs to the throne so that she could rule. *2 Kings 11:1; 2 Chronicles 22:10*
 - 4 **Reigned six years.** She ruled Judah from Jerusalem, the only woman to do so. *2 Kings 11:3*
 - 5 **Promoted Baal.** A house of Baal stood in Jerusalem with its own priest, Mattan. Her sons stripped the temple of the LORD for Baal. *2 Kings 11:18; 2 Chronicles 24:7*
 - 6 **Cried treason and fell.** She saw the boy king by the pillar, rent her clothes, and cried "Treason, Treason." She was slain outside the temple. *2 Kings 11:13-16*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Athaliah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 8:16–27; 2 Chronicles 21:5–22:4	Her husband's and son's reigns
2 Kings 11:1–20; 2 Chronicles 22:10–23:21	Her reign and death
2 Chronicles 24:7	Called "that wicked woman"; her sons broke into God's house
2 Kings 8:19	God spares Judah for David's sake, a lasting light
Echo: 2 Kings 9:30–37	Jezebel dies in Jehu's revolt that same year
Echo: 2 Samuel 7:16	David's house and kingdom established for ever

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 2:13–16	Herod tries to kill a royal child, who is kept safe
Echo: Matthew 1:1–16	David's royal line traced to Jesus

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Athaliah do when she learned her son was dead (2 Kings 11:1)?
- Understand:* Why do you think the writers of Kings and Chronicles cared so much that one baby from David's line survived?
- Apply:* Athaliah's family shaped her, and she shaped her son. What influences, good or bad, have been passed down in your family?
- Apply:* Jehosheba acted quietly and bravely. Who around you needs protecting, and what is one thing you could do for them?